INTRODUCTION

An introduction to the special issue on "Language, Politics and Media: The Hong Kong protests"

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Protests and social movements have become part of Hong Kong's local politics since the 1970s. However, protests against the proposed extradition bill in 2019–20 turned out to be the most violent political mass movement in Hong Kong after its return to the People's Republic of China in 1997. It not only drew wide international attention but also evoked another round of "news war" over Hong Kong (Lee et al. 2002). This special issue collects six articles which address the representations of the protests in Hong Kong by different parties on different media platforms. Adopting a critical discourse analysis approach, these studies examine discursive strategies employed in media representations of the protests and the ideologies and power struggles at play. It aims to present different perspectives towards the issue and shed light on the complex relations between language, media and politics in the representations of the Hong Kong protests.

Keywords: language use, politics, media, critical discourse analysis, corpus linguistics, protests, Hong Kong, extradition bill, news discourse, social media

1. Language, politics and media

It has been more than twenty years since Hong Kong returned to the People's Republic of China on 1 July 1997 after 155 years of British colonial rule. Under the general framework of "one country, two systems", Hong Kong has since made some remarkable achievements in economic development and maintained its status as an international financial centre. However, its political progress has frequently been a cause of concern and growing conflicts, including those that can be witnessed in several protests in Hong Kong in recent years, for instance, the protest against the national education curriculum in 2012, the Umbrella Move-

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ment in 2014 and the protests against the proposed anti-extradition bill in 2019. As an important ideological battleground between the East and the West (Lee et al. 2002), the protests in Hong Kong have received wide attention from international news media and become an issue of international concern. Their particular ways of representing Hong Kong protests can not only shape public understandings of the issue, but, more importantly, (de)legitimize the protests and affect their potential outcomes (Gamson and Wolfsfeld 1993).

The importance of news media in protests and social movements has been widely acknowledged and extensively examined (Gamson 1995; Gamson and Wolfsfeld 1993; Lee and Chan 2011). News media provides a platform for protesters to express and legitimate their positions and requests, expand their influences and mobilize their advocacies (Cottle 2008; Ghobrial and Wilkins 2015). Nevertheless, not all public protests receive equal attention from news media, and there is often disconnect between media representations and actual events (Greer and McLaughlin 2010). While positive and prominent coverage of a protest in news media can help legitimize the protesters' positions and mobilise public support, negative and marginal representations of a protest can delegitimize the protesters' positions and contribute to the failure of the protest (Gamson and Wolfsfeld 1993). The growth and survival of a protest relies, to a certain extent, on the protesters' capacity to garner media attention and the ways they are constructed in news media (Wisler and Giugni 1999).

The media serves as a contested space of meaning rather than a mere reflection of reality (Fowler 1991; Fairclough 1995). Previous studies have demonstrated that news selection and coverage of protests tend to be influenced by a range of factors, including the nature and the location of a protest, individual biases, the norms and conventions of journalistic practices, national interests and cultural preferences (Gans 1979; Shoemaker 1982; Boyle, McLeod and Armstrong 2012). As regards the nature of protests, the violent protests tend to be more newsworthy than peaceful protests (McLeod 2007). In order to draw media attention and force the authorities to accept their appeals, some protestors will resort radical measures on some occasions (Button, John and Brearley 2002; McLeod and Hertog 1999). However, radical groups tend to be given more unfavourable coverage than moderate groups, and they often tend to be portrayed as deviant and threatening (Shoemaker 1984; Boykoff 2006). As McLeod (2007, 186) suggests, "protest groups often find themselves in a double-bind: be ignored by the media, or resort to drama and risk that these events might be used to delegitimize the group".

In addition, international news representations of social protests in other socio-political contexts tend be filtered by the lens of national interests (Lee et al. 2002; Fang 1994, Wittebols 1996, Ghobrial and Wilkins 2015). According to Wittebols (1996, 359), US media tended to treat "protesters against adversary govern-

ments more favourably than friendly governments". In their coverage of a labour dispute protest in a Communist country, US media put the blame mainly on the government. By contrast, in a similar protest occurring in a capitalist country, US media constructed the protesters as deviant and violent (Lee and Craig 1992). The same ideological framework has also been identified in Chinese press (Fang 1994). Protests of the same type were also constructed with different labels and syntactic structures when they occurred in ideologically different countries. As such, it is necessary to conduct certain comparative studies to examine the representations of a protest by news media from different countries, probing into to what extent and in what ways they align with their national interests in producing their own versions of the protest (Lee et al. 2002).

Previous studies on the mediation of protests have also addressed a wide variety of ways media and communication are related to protests and social movements (Cammaerts 2012, 2013; Chouliaraki 2013; Cammaerts, Mattoni and McCurdy 2013; Krzyżanowski, Triandafyllidou and Wodak 2018; Uldam 2013; Jungherr, Schoen and Jürgens 2016). Cammaerts (2012) proposes the concept of "mediation opportunity structure" to capture the varied ways media and communication are related to protests and social movements. Based on this concept, the mediation of protests can be examined at three different levels: the first level concerns mainstream media representations and examines the various ways the activists use to garner media attention; the second level concerns the strategies of self-mediation in order to produce counter-narratives to mainstream media representations; the third level addresses resistance practices mediated through technology (Cammaerts 2012). Therefore, it requires the examination of not only the mainstream media representations of protests but also the repertoire of contentious action available for protesters (Lee 2018; Thomas and Stehling 2015; Woller 2018).

The six articles in this special issue are devoted to a close examination of media representations of the Hong Kong protests, especially anti-extradition bill protests which broke out in 2019. All these articles take a critical discourse analysis (CDA) approach (Wodak and Meyer 2016b; Wodak and Forchtner 2018; Fairclough 2003; van Dijk 1991). CDA views discourse as a social practice as well as a discourse practice, and tries to explicate the dynamic and subtle relations between language, power (abuse) and ideology (Wodak and Meyer 2016b). The basic assumption is that discourse is socially shaped and socially shaping (Fairclough 1995). A critical examination of discourse should examine not only linguistic choices at different levels of language but also the ideologies and power struggles involved behind these linguistic choices (Wodak and Meyer 2016b). Therefore, CDA is an interdisciplinary approach which underlines both linguistic analysis and social analysis. It tries to utilize the theories and methods from lin-

guistics and other related disciplines (Wodak and Meyer 2016a). It is particularly concerned about "the way social power abuse, dominance, and inequality are enacted, reproduced and resisted by text and talk in the social and political context" (van Dijk 2011, 352). The CDA approach has showcased its productivity in revealing power struggles and ideological frameworks behind media representations of protests (Trew 1979; van Dijk 1991; Hackett and Zhao 1994; Fang 1994; Lee and Craig 1992). It is particularly concerned about the mediatization of politics through news media in view of the fact it has turned "political practices into a process of mediated attention-seeking rather than of political representation and policy making" (Krzyżanowski, Triandafyllidou and Wodak 2018, 6). The basic argument is that "mediated reality matters more than any kind of actual or objective reality" (Strömbäck 2008, 239).

Two earlier special issues in this journal were devoted to protests in Hong Kong and other parts of the world. One was edited by Luisa Martín Rojo (2014), providing articles covering different national contexts throughout the world, and focusing particularly on the spatial dynamics of the protests; and the other was edited by John Flowerdew and Rodney H. Jones (2016), revealing how different discourses and discursive practices from other political movements were appropriated and adapted to the representations of the Occupy Central movement (also known as the Umbrella Movement) in Hong Kong. This issue aims to expose the competing perspectives adopted towards the Hong Kong protests (the 2019-20 anti-extradition bill protests in particular) and the discursive strategies employed for the construction of social realities (social actions, social relations and social identities). We endorse the *pluralism* in both perspectives and methodology by inviting researchers from Chinese mainland, Hong Kong and the UK and by examining news media from different parties, including Hong Kong, Chinese mainland, the UK and US. While the mainstream media still hold the advantages of agenda setting, reaching a wide audience and conferring status and legitimacy (Lee 2014), social media have also been increasingly used by some protest groups to communicate with the public and enlist public support (Purbrick 2019; Lee 2020a). The analysis of the representations of the protests in mainstream media is further complemented by a close examination of the strategies used by the protesters in social media in order to show the multiple ways of legitimating their own positions and delegitimating the positions of others. It is expected that a plural and complementary view of the competing perspectives towards the protests can illuminate the significant role of media discourse in the representations of the protests and constructing the identities of different parties concerned in the protests.

Besides, while previous studies on media representations of protests used to rely on the close analysis of a small sample of news texts (Hart 2014; Fang 1994;

Lee and Craig 1992), most studies in this special issue try to incorporate the methods and theories of corpus linguistics (CL). The basic assumption is that a combination of the methods and theories of CL and CDA can reveal some findings which cannot be acquired through the close qualitative analysis of a small sample of texts (Baker et al. 2008; Baker 2006; Haarman and Lombardo 2009). More importantly, it can address the accumulative effects of media discourse, reduce researcher bias, produce empirical evidences to the findings and make the analysis replicable (Baker 2006). While the potentials and benefits of combining CDA and CL have been widely acknowledged (Mautner 2009a, 2009b; Partington 2004), recent studies have underlined the significance of the "balanced" combination or the "synergy" of the theories and methods of CDA and CL (Baker et al. 2008; Liu 2015, 2017). In this regard, the computer-assisted corpus analytic tools can contribute to the efficient automatic analysis of a large sample of texts and provide the entry points for further detailed discourse analysis. In this special issue, different CL methods have been employed, such as frequencies, collocates, keywords, clusters, key semantic categories and sentiment analysis. In order to interpret and explain the results generated by corpus-analytic tools in an insightful way, different linguistic theories and concepts have been used by the authors of the articles in this special issue, for instance, the appraisal theory, the discourse of illusion, the politics of fear, and the metalinguistic tactics. It is expected that a combination of the theories and methods of CDA and CL can generate illuminating findings on the discursive strategies employed by different parties and the ideologies and power struggles involved in the protests.

2. The protests in Hong Kong and the anti-extradition bill movement

Protests and social movements have been part of Hong Kong's local politics since the 1970s (Chiu and Lui 2000; Lee et al. 2021) where they have come to be viewed as effective means to express public discontent and resist the "unfavourable" government policies and regulations in Hong Kong (Lee 2014). One typical example was the mass protest on 1 July 2003, which successfully forced the Hong Kong government to postpone the proposed national security ordinance (Lee 2020b). This gave rise to a series of protests in the following years and turned "protest marches and rallies into normalised events" (Lee 2020b, 20). However, due to the conservative political culture in Hong Kong, the majority of the protests used to be peaceful, without causing much disorder and disruptions (Lee 2020b; Chung 2020). However, a new trend has appeared since the late 2000s and early 2010s as some protesters view the peaceful marches on the streets as an ineffective means to garner enough media attention (Lee et al. 2021; Cheng 2014). Therefore, the protests

in Hong Kong have become increasingly conflictual in recent years. In view of the growing political demands of some Hong Kong people and the uncompromising stance of the Chinese government, the conflictual protests have grown to be a "new" normality (Krzyżanowski 2020) in Hong Kong.

In February, 2019, Hong Kong's Security Bureau submitted a paper to the city's legislature proposing amendments to extradition laws that would allow criminal suspects to be sent to the Chinese mainland and Taiwan for trial. The bill was aimed at establishing a system for case-by-case fugitive transfers between Hong Kong and regions with which it did not already have agreements. One frequently cited cause for this bill was a murder case which occurred in early 2018 when a Hong Kong resident Tongjia CHEN fled to Hong Kong after he murdered his pregnant girlfriend Xiaoying PAN in Taiwan. Although CHEN admitted to the Hong Kong police that he was the murderer, he could not be charged in Hong Kong due to the lack of agreement on extradition between Hong Kong, Taiwan and Chinese mainland. However, this bill caused widespread fear in Hong Kong mainly due to the distrust towards the jurisdiction and legal system in the Chinese mainland. Some Hong Kong people were worried that the bill would be used by the Chinese government to exert its influence in Hong Kong and bring damage to Hong Kong's autonomy and civil liberties (Ku 2007, 2020). At the beginning, some opponents besieged the Legislative Council in order to stop passing the bill, but the Hong Kong government stood firm on this issue (Lee et al. 2021). The protests thus turned increasingly confrontational, with some streets blocked, some shops – especially of the owners who spoke against protests – vandalised and some clashes taking place between protesters and the police (Lee et al. 2020).

Although the Hong Kong government announced the suspension of the bill on 15 June 2019, it still failed to pacify the protesters due to their worries about the possibility of reintroduction. The protesters even put forward "five demands", including "for the protests not to be characteristic as a 'riot'", for "amnesty for arrested protesters", for "an independent inquiry into the alleged police brutality", and for the "implementation of complete universal suffrage" as well as for "the withdrawal of the bill" (BBC News, 28 November 2019). As the Hong Kong government would not make further concessions to these demands, the protests still continued and would not stop until the outbreak of the COVID-19. Although it is still too early to give an accurate assessment of their actual and potential consequences, the anti-extradition bill protests can be regarded as a watershed in Hong Kong's history of social movements (Ku 2020; Lee et al. 2021). This also pushed the National People's Congress in China to pass the imposition of national security law on Hong Kong (Lee et al. 2020). This event also drew intensive international media attention and news media represented another battlefield of different ideologies and opinions.

3. Overview of the special issue

This special issue consists of six articles. Four articles are devoted to the representations of the Hong Kong protests in mainstream newspapers from four countries and regions, including the UK, the US, Hong Kong and the Chinese mainland. Although these news media come from different media systems and serve different functions in their respective journalism systems (Hallin and Mancini 2004, 2012), they are all quality English-language newspapers which are supposed to compete in the international arena to express their different voices about the Hong Kong protests. As the former colonizer of Hong Kong, the British government promised to keep a close watch on Hong Kong when it retreated from Hong Kong on 1 July 1997, and British news media always showed a strong interest in the protests of Hong Kong (Liu and Jiang 2019). The US, on the other hand, volunteered to be the new "guardian" of post-colonial Hong Kong and has maintained substantial political and economic interest in Hong Kong since its return to China (Martin 2007; Liu 2020). The political disputes in Hong Kong never failed to capture the media attention of US news media. However, previous studies have demonstrated that British and US news media, in spite of their ideological similarities, also show their own preferences in their representations of Hong Kong due to their different national interests (Liu 2020; Lee et al. 2000; Lee et al. 2002). As the most influential English-language newspaper in the Chinese mainland, *China Daily* (CD) communicates the voice of the Chinese government to the English-speaking world and the international community (Liu 2015; Wang and Ma 2021). It provides access to the official stance of the Chinese government towards the issues in Hong Kong. As a local quality English-language newspaper, *South China Morning Post* (SCMP) boasts "elite readership", because most of its readers are well-educated and well-paid (Cheng and Lam 2010). It plays a significant role in the media markets of Hong Kong (Liu and Zhong 2020).

The mass movements in Hong Kong used to be typically represented by the media as intergroup conflicts involving several parties. In order to help better understand protests in general, Guofeng Wang elaborates a schema for protests in her article. Based on this schema, the study adopts the corpus-assisted CDA approach in a balanced way and probes into how three British national newspapers, *The Times, The Guardian* and *The Telegraph*, represent the social actors involved in the 2019–20 protests. The results of keyword analysis, collocate analysis and concordance analysis show that the newspapers mainly use the predicational strategy to portray the Chinese government's control of Hong Kong, the inabilities of the Hong Kong government, police violence and the protestors' demand for universal suffrage. In addition, this article takes a particular interest in the construction of the role of Britain in the protests and examines whether

the UK holds to its promises to keep a close watch on Hong Kong. The newspapers suggest that Britain act as a mediator to shoulder a moral responsibility over its former colony. Their supportive attitudes towards the protestors and their suggestion of Britain as a mediator accords with Britain's foreign policies, national interests and its long-standing dominant ideology, which also indicates that the UK journalistic practice regarding Hong Kong issues is to a great extent politically motivated.

The article by Ming Liu and Jingxue Ma also combines CL and CDA to give a corpus-assisted discourse study (CADS) of the representations of anti-extradition bill in the prestigious American newspaper, the *New York Times*. With the primary purpose of examining how the newspaper addresses the changing trend in Hong Kong protests, it has three specific objectives: (1) to examine to what extent and in what way the representations conform to or deviate from the "protest paradigm"; (2) to examine the role of emotion discourses in NYT's protest representations; (3) to examine how they contribute to the constructions of concerned parties in the protests. The corpus analytic tools are employed in this study to give both automatic semantic tagging and the detailed analysis of some tokens in their specific contexts of use. The concepts of the "protest paradigm" and "the politics of fear" have been borrowed to test to what extent the representations of Hong Kong protests deviate from and conform to its traditional representations of Hong Kong protests. The findings show that while the newspaper still conforms to the "protest paradigm" by highlighting violence and deviant behaviours of the protesters (Hertog and McLeod 1995), it deviates from the "protest paradigm" by foregrounding police violence and downplaying what is seen as the violence of the protesters. Emotion has emerged as a distinct strategy in its representations of the protest and the politics of fear has been played to give a negative presentation of the Hong Kong government and the Chinese government and justify and legitimise the actions of the protesters. This study further confirms that the newspaper still aligns with its national interests and policy in its representations of Hong Kong protests. In the meantime, it has also showcased how the methods and theories of CL and CDA can be integrated to give a critical examination of media discourse.

Two comparative studies are then conducted to compare the representations of Hong Kong protests in an official English newspaper from Chinese mainland, i.e. *China Daily*, and a local Hong Kong English-language newspaper, i.e. *South China Morning Post*. Although both studies try to combine CDA and automatic corpus analysis, they differ in the specific theories and methods adopted, thus generating illuminating insights on the potential ways of combining the methods and theories of the two disciplines. The article by Xiuling Cao, Danqi Zhang and Qianjun Luo combines, for example, the appraisal theory and the analysis of key-

words and collocates. Its findings show that CD underlines the punishment of the illegal actions of protestors, while SCMP only expresses its criticism towards these actions. Besides, CD attributes the protest to the opposition camp's intention to build Hong Kong into a de facto independent political entity and dramatizes the severe consequences of the protest on the future prosperity of Hong Kong. However, SCMP highlights the widespread opposition to the bill in Hong Kong and the influence of the Chinese government in Hong Kong. The different preferences of the two newspapers in the representations of the protest can be attributed to the different roles and functions of the two newspapers in their respective sociopolitical contexts.

The article by Janet Ho and Ming Chiu proposes a multilevel and multivariate analytic approach to the portrayal of the key social actors (police, students, protesters, and governments) during the Umbrella Movement in SCMP and CD. The discourse-historical approach (DHA) in CDA has been combined here with the sentiment analysis of valence, arousal and dominance. The findings show that compared with CD, SMCP is more positive in emotional sentiments associated with students and protesters and more negative in emotional sentiments associated with the police and the government. Besides, SCMP shows preference for personal stories to give a personalized image of protesters and students, whereas CD tends to show preference for expert authority, rhetorical questions and imagined scenarios to express empathy towards the Hong Kong residents and create a villainized image of protesters. They show their different ways of framing students: CD frames student protesters as "powerless scapegoats", SCMP as "optimistic dreamers". This study represents a worthy attempt to integrate automatic sentiment analysis with CDA to give more efficient analysis of the data and present more illuminating findings about the relations between language, power and ideology.

Since the majority of the participants in the Hong Kong protests are young people relying on social media to expand their influence and advance their interests, the following two articles present an examination of the discursive strategies employed by the protesters to construct the collective identity of Hong Kong people. The article by Aditi Bhatia and Andrew S. Ross examines Twitter posts related to the 2019–20 protests and explores the public narrative among the collective identity of Hongkongers who opposed the bill. They draw on Bhatia's multiperspective analytic framework for the 'Discourse of Illusion' and propose to analyse discursive illusions through three interrelated aspects: historicity, linguistic and semiotic action and social impact. Corpus linguistic methods have also been used in this study as an entry point for a close qualitative analysis of the representations of Hong Kong, government action and police action in the Tweets and the Chief Executive Carrie Lam's media releases concerning the protests. The

representations of Hong Kong are concerned with Hong Kong's identity and core values. The protesters represent it as a battle for Hong Kong's soul and underline the urgency of the protest. The government downplays the protest by representing the protest as discontent and civic debate and Hong Kong as pluralistic society. In terms of the representation of government actions, on the other hand, the protesters tend to depict them as hard-hearted, while the government tries to present a rational contrast to irrational protesters. With regard to the representation of police actions, the protesters adopt the victim-aggressor category to underline the violent police actions, while the government tries to use legal metaphors to highlight a threatening situation needing to be protected by a brave and dedicated police force. They argue that social media emerges as a primary means for protesters to proliferate their conceptualization of the event and issues plaguing Hong Kong's socio-political landscape and underlines the significance in examining digital activism.

Finally, the article by Rodney Jones and Dennis Chau addresses a special discursive strategy (i.e. the metalinguistic tactics) used by participants in Hong Kong protests from 2014 to 2019. They argue that metalanguage (i.e. language about language) represents a unique tool for Hongkongers to draw distinctions between themselves and outsiders and among themselves. An examination of the metalinguistic tactics used by participants in Hong Kong protests can reveal a range of existent assumptions and attitudes about language. This study focuses on three kinds of metalinguistic tactics: (1) language mocking, especially the ridiculing of the police officers' linguistic practices; (2) linguistic obfuscation, the use of particular ways of speaking and writing to evade surveillance by authorities; (3) folk forensics, the analysis of the language of others in order to make claims about their place of origin and possible political affiliation. These tactics are examined in terms of both the "message war" between protesters and authorities and the broader debates about language and identity in the city. They can shed light on the intertwinement of language ideologies and political ideologies in Hong Kong and the opportunities and risks for protesters to use these tactics in the complex and volatile sociolinguistic environment in Hong Kong.

To sum up, anchored in the broad theoretical paradigm of CDA, these articles address the representations of the protests in Hong Kong from different perspectives and in different media platforms. Adopting the theories and methods from both CDA and corpus linguistics, social psychology and semiotics, they have revealed not only the different discursive strategies employed but also the ideologies and power struggles involved behind the protests. On the one hand, it is expected that this special issue can contribute to a better understanding of the protests in Hong Kong and the intricate and dynamic relations between language, media and politics in the unique and complex Hong Kong context. On the other

hand, it is expected that these studies can contribute to the growing literature of combining the methods and theories of CDA and other trends in discourse studies with a view to generating more innovative and illuminating studies on protests in general and the changing and expanding "repertoires of contention in Hong Kong" in particular (Chung 2020). It is argued that the confinement to a single perspective or methodology certainly fails to do justice to the complicated situations in Hong Kong and the power struggles behind them.

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